CAREER

Data Career Playbook

Salary, the switch plan and what interviewers actually look for, from 14 years in data.

- **Salary bands in India**
- **What moves you from ₹4 to ₹15 LPA**
- **90-day plan for career switchers**

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Salary bands in India

Indicative ranges. City, company type and domain change these a lot.

0-2 years

Data Analyst ₹4-8 LPA · Data Scientist ₹6-12 LPA

2-5 years

Data Analyst ₹8-15 LPA · Data Scientist ₹12-25 LPA

5-8 years

Data Analyst ₹15-25 LPA · Data Scientist ₹25-40 LPA

8+ years

Analytics Lead ₹25-45 LPA · Lead Data Scientist ₹40-70 LPA

Company type

Product companies and GCCs often pay 1.5 to 2 times a service company at the same experience.

Biggest jump usually comes from switching companies at 2-3 years with strong projects, not from waiting for appraisals.

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₹4 LPA to ₹15 LPA

The skills are not the only difference. How you show them matters as much.

- **SQL beyond basics**

  Window functions, CTEs, and explaining query logic out loud.

- **One BI tool done properly**

  Power BI with a clean data model and DAX, not just drag and drop.

- **Talk in impact**

  "Cut weekly reporting from 6 hours to 20 minutes" beats "built a dashboard".

- **Pick a domain**

  BFSI, e-commerce or supply chain. Domain knowledge gets you paid more.

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90-day switch plan

For non-tech or non-data backgrounds. 1.5 to 2 hours a day.

- **Weeks 1-3: Excel**
  Lookups, pivots, one sales dashboard.
- **Weeks 4-7: SQL**
  50 questions using the 8 patterns.
- **Weeks 8-10: Power BI**
  One end-to-end report with a star schema.
- **Weeks 11-12: Python + stats**
  One EDA notebook on a real dataset.
- **Week 13: Apply**
  Resume with numbers, LinkedIn updated, 20 targeted applications.

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What I check in interviews

After taking many data interviews, these decide most outcomes.

- **Can you explain your own project?**
  Without reading. Why you chose that approach and what you would do differently.
- **Do you ask the business question first?**
  Before writing SQL, ask what decision the numbers will support.
- **Can you spot a wrong number?**
  Sanity checks: totals, row counts, sudden spikes.
- **Resume with numbers**
  Rows, hours saved, revenue, accuracy. Tools alone say nothing.

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